কালীবাড়ি খবর

KALIBARI NEWS

(Registered Charity 1158269)
Visit us at: www.londonkalibari.org.uk

Kalibari Centre: 18 Byron Road, Wealdstone, Harrow, HA3 7ST
Issue 25, Nov 2020

From the Trustee Chairman

I hope you are well and coping with the difficulties we are facing at the moment. Unfortunately due to the pandemic, London Kalibari has been unable to organise our annual Kalipuja this year – I have just been able to go to the Kalibari Centre and offer Ma a fruit and flower and light a candle and say a prayer for us all.

It is also with great sadness that I have to announce the death of our treasurer Mrinal Choudhury, our beloved “Mrinalda”, on 1 August. This newsletter is a tribute to his long service for London Kalibari. I am also sad to tell you of the death of Mrs Chandra Choudhury, a much-loved supporter of London Kalibari. A tribute to Chandra is also to be found later in this newsletter.

During this pandemic it has been difficult for Kalibari without contributions from events and meetings to pay rent, rate and utility bills. But just before his death Mrinalda applied for a Covid 19 grant for £5,700 from HM Government and the National Lottery Community Fund, to tide us over the next 6 months. We were successful and have just received the grant in full – thanks to Mrinalda.

London Kalibari Trustees:

Dr Satya Chatterjee, Mrs Jayati Das (Secretary), Mrs Krishna Ghosh, Dr Sudin Mandal (Chair) and Mrs Debjani Sengupta.

Core Support Group:
Mrs Rama Choudhury, Mrs Gita Dutta, Mrs Babli Mazumdar, Mr Kanu Roy, Mr Snehangshu Basu, Mrs Giti Ray and Mrs Dipti Chatterjee.

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General Secretary's Report:
What a year this has been for all of us. Apart from the pandemic we have lost Mr. Mrinal Choudhury. The pioneer and stalwart of London Kalibari. Mrinalda and Rama with Dr. Bhaben Sarkar came to my place here in Sawbridgeworth on 1st August. We spent the whole day with laughter, leg-pulling, eating and enjoying each moment. Next morning the bombshell came from Sudin. I shall myself be very grateful to God that his last day on this earth was so pleasant and I will cherish the memories.

We have tried to keep you posted with emails. We are planning to have a meeting of the trustees virtually. Wonderful to know that the technology is so advanced! The workload for some of us has increased somewhat. We did not know in all honesty the input Mrinalda made to LKB. Next year if we can go back to normality then we will be very happy for any help that you so kindly offer.
Our premises need some work which is being overseen by the ever helpful Mr. Navin Shah.

You all just stay there safe and well. Till we meet again. Joy Ma Kali

Treasurer's Statement:

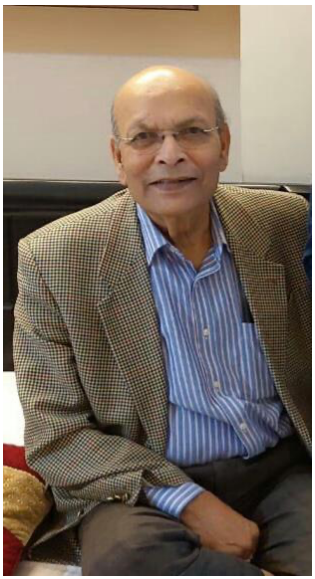
The monthly expenditure is around £750. We have a standing order of about £250 per month and an income of some £1,300 per month from other sources, such as events, luncheon club, HMRS tax refund, which leaves us with a surplus of some £800 per month which goes into the building fund.

This year, finance has been a problem due to the pandemic. However, before his death, Mrinal Choudhury got an agreement with the Landlord to reduce the rent to £300 per month for 6 months. This has helped. As already stated we have received a grant of £5,700 from HM Government and the National Lottery Community Fund, thanks to Mrinal Choudhury. It is possible that we shall break even in this financial year, which means that there will be a very small addition to our Building Fund which now stands around £200,000. We are investing this money for 6 months as we do not need it immediately.

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Mrinal Choudhury - Eulogy
1938 to 2020

By his son Avijit.



BUSY LIFE

Baba always led a busy life, whether during his working career or during his retired life, where he was active with more charities than many of us know that exist. Throughout his lifetime, his memory was faultless, so much so, he always knew someone from somewhere and could find a connection, which is what made him the networker that he was.

Despite the arrival of smartphones, if he needed a backup, he would refer to his blue diary in his top left pocket, which seemed to be staple part of his uniform for as long as I can remember.

PUBLIC SPEAKING

Baba never feared public speaking especially in later life, in fact he grew to love it, sometimes too much, especially when his speech at my wedding clocked more than 30 minutes. I always remember him saying I wasn't shy, but I wasn't really a public speaker, but when I became Mayor, I felt I really enjoyed it, which we all recognised when he didn't hold back in taking the stage.

I will always remember him as MR SOCIALABLE or THE NETWORKER

Watching Baba from a young age, Baba taught me over the years how to make friends and nurture great friendships. He always had the ability to find something in common with whoever he spoke to.

Whether it be "where are you from?" Which triggered a follow-up question of Oh, I know so and so from there. To finding an ice-breaker to open up the conversation, which ultimately, lead to him being remembered by all those he came across. So much so, even the Ambulance man that came to the house in June, remembered him from his time as Mayor.

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HOSTING

For the 58 years Baba lived in London, he happily hosted family and friends and friends of family, friends of friends, children of friends or sometimes children studying in the UK, we rarely knew all because he was happy to share a roof over their head and generally didn't like to say no. In fact our guesthouse, unbeknown to me was so well known, one of my uncles was coming home to our house in a black cab and got to Kenton where we lived and said I can't quite remember the street, but I'll recognise it, to which the cab driver said, oh, do you want to go to the house where all my Indian passenger go and stay, and so they ended up back at our house!

One of the many benefits of all these folk staying with us, was I crafted my Bengali and grew up listening to his fabulous words of wisdom.

DREAM BIG

Baba spent his is whole life dreaming about cultural prosperity and nurturing good humanity for all, rather than for himself. I along with many others, will reminisce his self-less traits and his ambition for the all Indian and Bengali communities to be stronger together through the richness of dance, drama and in recognition of their heritage.

In later years he found a talent and love for writing poetry in Bengali, typically to recognise people and their lifetimes, which continued his journey on the public stage.

Having a strong moral compass and hard work ethics, were traits that ultimately lead to be him being recognised as Mayor of Harrow in 2011, the same year he turned 73, which energised him to continue sharing his passion and drive for community causes for many years to come.

FAMILY

Family was always a big part of Baba's life, having grown up as the eldest son in a family nine which grew up in a joint family structure. He spent his whole life reminiscing those days in Chaitanyapur and was always willing to help any siblings or cousins, be they 1st, 2nd, 3rd and beyond in whatever way possible. His annual trips to India were always driven by seeing if he could turn what was Chaitanyapur's equivalent to the Best Exotic Marigold Hotel, into a place for all to experience. One of our family's greatest moments in 2018 was getting my wife Claire and our daughters Ria and Ani to the village where he grew up to fulfil a dream of a lifetime.

Baba's quick sense of humour and big heart was never more evident, than when he was around his family & especially his grandchildren, who he loved to spend time with, whether in the UK or abroad.

2020 was the year that Baba and Ma clocked 50 years of happy marriage, which was built on love and support for each other, his washing up and hoovering skills and Ma's rationing of sandesh as a reward.

Whilst many will remember him for his self-less charitable works, Yoga & Spirituality, alongside guiding principles based on his soft tone. To me he was a father & baba who I will remember as a man with a big heart, a big mind and a big smile.

My Tribute to Mrinal by Sujit (Sujan) Bhattacharjee

In our life, we come across innumerable people. They all leave some kind of impression. But there are a few for whom our remembrance remains indelible. Mrinal Chaudhury is one such person who I will always remember as one of my truest and closest friends.
My close association with Mrinal goes back quite a long way. Our friendship began and evolved in unison because of our mutual interest and affinity in artistic matters and local politics. My best memories include the time we spent organising, attending and participating in various related cultural and political events. Mrinal had a significant influence on all these, showing tremendous energy and commitment. This was further evident in his practical support for and links with many organisations including Kalibari and in his role as a local councillor and his well deserved rise to the position of the Mayor of Harrow.

He was also passionate about poetry. I fondly remember the occasion of the launching of one of his recent books "Kabita Guchchh", He kindly asked me to say a few words about this book. A pertinent question I raised on that occasion was how could Mrinal find the time to write and compile not one but 121 poems of deep perceptions in that book. However I also found the answer in one of the poems within called "Bhabuk Mon" (A Thoughtful Mind). Mrinal indeed had a thoughtful mind to enrich his emotions and thought.

Mrinal's sudden death came as a tragic loss to all those who knew him. Bur let us remember him with smiles and not sorrows for all the joy he gave us throughout all the years he was with us. And may his memories as a devoted husband and a loving father help Roma, Avijit and his family to find some comfort for their sad loss.

My Tribute to Mrinal, by Tony McNulty (former Harrow Labour MP)

I am very proud to have known Mrinal Choudhury and to have counted him as both a friend and a comrade. He worked tirelessly and unswervingly for the community - particularly through his work with the Labour Party and with London Kalibari. I know that he also worked in many other ways for the community and was always ready to lend people a helping hand. He was always the very gentlest of men and had both a kindness and an intellect second to none. He taught me many lessons about life and politics that made me a better person and these are memories that I shall cherish forever. I will remember him as both a very close friend and as an enormous and unstinting servant of the Labour Party and he held many offices including Councillor for Edgware, London Kalibari and the wider community in Harrow.

Above all, I shall remember him with that ever-widening and slightly mischievous smile on his face that was always there when we met. He had a warm word for everyone and will be missed as one of the giants of the communities in Harrow and as someone always ready to serve and help. I will also remember his kindness and support when my dear late father was going through his most recent bout of illness.

Mrinal managed to combine both a kindness and an energy that made him a very special person. He was the proudest husband and father and everyone's friend. The single most important thing I can say is to repeat that I am very proud to have known him and feel deeply blessed that I had the privilege of knowing him. A friend and comrade who leaves behind an enormous gap in our lives - he will know that he is missed, but above all that he made a difference and for that we will love him forever."

Chandra Choudhury- Eulogy

By her son Avishek



Ma was born and grew up in Varanasi, where she was educated in BHU. She particularly excelled in sports such as badminton, even winning a championship cup prize. In addition, she excelled in the classroom, becoming fluent in at least half a dozen Indian and non-Indian languages. All this at a time when women doing anything outside of the kitchen was frowned upon in old 1900s India, this strong fiery trait for independence she shared with all her siblings. All members of her childhood family didn't follow the traditional Bengali upbringing where you were told to become educated, then become a clerk for their whole life, and then retire at old age on a clerk's pension. She worked as a very good schoolteacher where she received many promotions in pay scale, and she was a fully devoted Mother.

Whenever she would enter the Kalibari, or even any room for that matter, it was as if a bright light had entered. She would always be incredibly happy and bring joy to even the most depressed glummest faces. And it did not end there, as soon as her homemade recipe coconut ladoos came out, there would be near riots in the Kalibari, some would take several at a time due to them having such a wonderful taste. For this reason, Ma always had the biggest plastic container, and even had to make the container into multiple layers, with kitchen foil between each layer of coconut ladoos so that she could fill this large container all the way up to the top with this lovely sweet. Only Ma's coconut ladoos would cause people to forget their diabetes and take as many handfuls of ladoos as they could! Many people feel the urge to show gold bangles and other ornaments and money because they want to feel less inadequate. However for Ma this showing was unnecessary because there was a million tonnes of 24 carat gold bangle in her heart, in her mind, in her spirit, and in her love; which is something I think only Heaven and Atma or a similar divine entity can gift to a human person.

A poem by Mrinal Choudhury

ভাল লাগে

ভাল লাগে প্রভাতের রবির কিরণ;
ভাল লাগে জন্মের উষ্ণ উৎপেরন।
ভাললাগে জন্মের আনন্দের আলোড়ন;
ভাললাগে আনন্দের অভিনন্দন।
ভাললাগে সবুজে সাজানো মঞ্চ;
ভাললাগে নানা রঙের ফুলের মালঞ্চ।
ভাললাগে মাতৃ স্নেহের পরিণতা;
ভাললাগে শিশু মনের পবিত্রতা।
ভাললাগে কিশোর কিশোরীর কৌতহল;
ভাললাগে তাদের প্রাণের উচ্ছাসের কোলাহল।
ভাললাগে যুবক যুবতির চিন্তার গভীরতা;
ভাললাগে তাদের সৃষ্টির উৎদমতা।
ভাললাগে উৎসবের সমারহের পবিত্রতা;
ভাললাহে আনন্দের স্নিগ্ধতা।
ভাললাগে মানুষের আদান প্রদান;
ভাললাগে তাদের দিব্য প্রেরণার আলিঙ্গন।
ভাললাগে অন্তরযামীর অনন্ত বিকাশ;
ভাললাগে দিব্য চেতনার প্রকাশ।
ভাললাগে মানুষের অমর হবার প্রচেষ্টা;
ভাললাগে মহাবিদায়ের অমর বার্ত্ত।
৪ই নভেম্বর ২০০৬
হ্যারো, লন্ডন

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